suggested that we keep it a secret till you complete your assignment. That your father agreed to it.'

Pillai put his hand to his forehead, and walked into the car. I waved them goodbye. Turning around, I saw Sampath frozen. I shook him.

'What happened?' I said.

Sampath puffed his cheeks, he wasn't blinking.

'Sir, now I am really scared of you. Now on I can't see you the way I had so far.'

I didn't analyse the meaning of what Sampath said, and just replied, 'Now, let's get back to work.'

Later I learnt that Balakrishnan was, as I expected, furious at what I had done. His father explained for many days the conversation he had with me. Two weeks later, I got a letter from Balakrishnan. It was a detailed letter, written by a man who had gone through untold sorrow, helplessness and fury to emerge strong-willed and mature. It said that he felt I did the wrong thing by not telling him because his immediate return could have been some solace to his wife. He also felt that I was right, since the three months in Vernon added immensely to his understanding of space programmes and that he felt more confident of contributing for India.

On my return to India, Balakrishnan actively participated in the development of the Vikas engine, without once talking about the episode. Even today, I am unsure if what I did was right. I have no right to sit in judgment of this decision, which I forced on Subbaiah. After reading the letter twice, I plunged back into work at SEP.

Life or death made no difference to the bean counters in the government departments. As such the division of our scientists into two groups—one called the '75 man years group' (75MYG) headed by SEP officials, and the other the '25 man years group' (25MYG) reporting to me—was causing me problems. The 75MYG scientists enjoyed privileges of SEP, including vacations.

'Soon expect a rebellion if you don't remove these discriminations,' my wife warned.